

CARNEGIE MELLON UNIVERSITY

Team SWOT Analysis Assignment

Team 10

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70-100 Global Business

PART II – Analysis of SWOT

STRENGTHS

- 1. Academic Excellence and Research Opportunities**
- 2. Interdisciplinary (cross departments, e.g. Tech and Arts) Research and Collaboration**
- 3. Diverse and Inclusive Campus Experience**

STRENGTH 1 – Academic Excellence and Research Opportunities

CMU's most prominent strength lies in its unwavering commitment to academic excellence, which fosters a highly skilled talent pool that enhances its brand reputation. In any process, there are three components: input, process, and output. Given CMU's exceptional output, it is evident that the university employs a distinctive approach. This approach includes a strong emphasis on interdisciplinary research, enabling students to engage with cutting-edge projects and apply theoretical knowledge in practical settings, thereby fostering innovation. Additionally, CMU's partnerships with leading corporate industries further enhance these opportunities, providing students with valuable real-world experience that sets them apart from their competitors. According to the [U.S. News & World Report](#), CMU ranks 1st in the nation for graduate computer science and graduate engineering programs, making it an attractive choice for students seeking a high-caliber education.

STRENGTH 2 – Interdisciplinary (cross departments, e.g. Tech and Arts) Research and Collaboration

Carnegie Mellon University is a brand that is recognized for AI and its commitment to interdisciplinary research, encouraging collaboration across disciplines which is aimed to solve complex problems. There are centers like Cylab that bring experts from different disciplines to tackle pressing problems like cybersecurity challenges. These efforts reflect CMU's mission to foster innovation through the integration of diverse disciplines. ([Carnegie Mellon University, n.d.](#); [Metro21: Smart Cities Institute, n.d.](#)).

Additionally, CMU supports interdisciplinary academic programs like the *Integrated Innovation Institute*, which merges engineering, design, and business, and the *Entertainment Technology Center*, which blends arts and computer science. These programs equip students to navigate the increasingly cross-disciplinary nature of today's workforce and contribute to cutting-edge research that impacts industries globally ([Integrated Innovation Institute, n.d.](#); [Entertainment Technology Center, n.d.](#)).

STRENGTH 3 – Diverse and Inclusive Campus Experience

Finding a combination of academic excellence, cultural diversity, and inclusivity is challenging, yet CMU excels in all three areas. The university actively promotes inclusivity through various initiatives and organizations, fostering a welcoming environment for students from diverse backgrounds. This commitment is reflected in a student body representing over 100 countries, enriching classroom discussions and preparing students for a globalized workforce. According to CMU's Office of Institutional Research, the university has experienced a significant increase in underrepresented minority enrollment, highlighting its dedication to cultivating an equitable learning environment ([CMU Institutional Research, 2023](#)).

WEAKNESSES

1. **High Tuition Costs**
2. **Comparatively Low Name/Brand Value (i.e. compared to institutions like MIT, Ivy League Schools, etc.)**
3. **Lack of Vibrant Campus Life/Experience**

WEAKNESS 1 – High Tuition Costs

The cost of attendance at Carnegie Mellon University is significantly high compared to many other institutions, which can deter prospective students from applying or enrolling. For the 2024-2025 academic year, total estimated costs, including tuition, fees, and living expenses, can exceed \$86,000 per year for undergraduate students ([CMU](#)). This financial burden is compounded by rising tuition rates and the increasing costs of living, particularly in urban areas like Pittsburgh, where CMU is located.

While CMU offers financial aid packages, the high overall cost may create barriers for low- and middle-income families, resulting in a less diverse student body and potentially limiting CMU's appeal to a broader audience. This challenge poses a threat to CMU's competitiveness, especially as alternative educational pathways, such as online programs and community colleges, offer more affordable options.

WEAKNESS 2 – Comparatively Low Name/Brand Value (i.e. compared to institutions like MIT, Ivy League Schools, etc.)

Despite its strong programs in technology and engineering, CMU often struggles with brand recognition when compared to prestigious institutions like MIT or Ivy League schools. This discrepancy can affect the university's ability to attract top talent and significant funding, as prospective students and faculty may prioritize more recognizable schools. The perception of brand value impacts recruitment efforts, alumni engagement, and the university's overall standing in global rankings. As a result, CMU may miss out on high-achieving applicants who

gravitate toward more prestigious names, hindering its potential for growth and influence in the academic and research communities.

This gap in attracting top-tier individuals could eventually hinder CMU's growth, innovation potential, and influence in the academic and research circles, ultimately affecting its long-term success and competitiveness globally.

WEAKNESS 3 – Lack of Vibrant Campus Life/Experience

Another identified weakness is the perception of limited campus life and student experiences at CMU. While the university offers a rigorous academic environment, some students report that the social scene is less vibrant compared to peer institutions. This limitation can affect student satisfaction, retention rates, and the overall college experience. Many students seek a well-rounded education that includes extracurricular activities, networking opportunities, and social engagement, which can be crucial for personal and professional development.

The lack of a thriving campus life may also contribute to feelings of isolation among students, particularly for those who value a strong sense of community or a lively social environment. This issue could deter potential applicants who prioritize not only academic rigor but also a balanced college experience that includes recreational activities and a lively campus scene. Addressing this weakness effectively could improve student satisfaction, boost retention, and make CMU more attractive to prospective students seeking a holistic university experience.

OPPORTUNITIES

- 1. Growing Demand for Tech/Analytics Talent**
- 2. Growing Demand for Online Learning and Remote Education**
- 3. Growing Demand for ESG Initiatives**

OPPORTUNITY 1 – Growing Demand for Tech/Analytics Talent

The growing demand for tech, analytics, machine learning, and artificial intelligence (AI) talent presents a significant opportunity for CMU due to its established reputation in cutting-edge research and education in these fields. As industries increasingly seek professionals skilled in AI, data science, and machine learning, CMU is well-positioned to meet this demand with its world-class programs. They can expand their programs, develop new AI technologies, and utilize them in education. According to the World Economic Forum, “Artificial intelligence (AI) can support education by automating administrative tasks, freeing teachers to focus more on teaching and personalized interactions with students, enhancing rather than replacing human-led teaching” (Milberg). Additionally, CMU’s School of Computer Science and renowned research centers, like the AI-focused Robotics Institute, give CMU a competitive advantage, allowing it to attract top talent and faculty who want to engage in transformative tech research.

Furthermore, Grand View Research shows that the global AI in education market is going to increase from \$2.75 billion in 2022 to \$32.37 billion in 2030, a stunning 36.0% compound

annual growth rate (CAGR) ([Grand View](#)). This growing focus on AI and tech innovation also enhances CMU's ability to create startup ecosystems, fostering entrepreneurship and the development of new technologies that further its role as a hub for tech-driven economic growth. As a leader in AI, CMU should seize this opportunity and expand. By expanding its tech and AI-focused programs and research, CMU can offer students the in-demand skills needed for industries ranging from autonomous vehicles to healthcare AI, etc. This would increase enrollment in relevant programs and help maintain its position as a leader in AI innovation, while also aligning graduates' skills with current job market needs. Furthermore, this demand opens up opportunities for industry partnerships, giving CMU the chance to collaborate with tech companies for research funding, internships, and job placements for its students.

OPPORTUNITY 2 – Growing Demand for Online Learning and Remote Education

Post-pandemic, the increasing demand for flexible online learning and remote education offers a significant opportunity for CMU to expand its reach and diversify its offerings. CMU has a strong reputation for academic excellence in technology and engineering, making it well-positioned to develop high-quality online programs, particularly in computer science, AI, and data analytics. Research shows that the e-learning market is projected to grow by 20.5% from 2022–2030 ([Polaris](#)). By offering online degrees and certifications, CMU can attract a broader, more diverse student body, including working professionals, international students, and individuals who cannot relocate or afford full-time, on-campus education.

CMU already offers online programs like Part-time MSBA that cater to working professionals who want to obtain a degree for their careers but are currently working and want to do both. Online learning offers flexibility for students who need to balance education with jobs or other responsibilities. This allows CMU to cater to a wider range of learners, including mid-career professionals seeking advanced credentials and people from underserved regions who can't access traditional campus resources. By expanding its online and remote learning platforms, CMU can meet the growing demand for flexible, high-quality education while maintaining its standing as a leader in technology and innovation. This strategy would allow CMU to capture new student demographics, enhance its global reputation, and create a more inclusive educational environment.

OPPORTUNITY 3 – Growing Demand for ESG Initiatives

The growing demand for ESG (Environmental, Social, and Governance) initiatives presents a strategic opportunity for CMU to enhance its academic, research, and industry collaborations while aligning with global trends in sustainability and corporate responsibility. ESG, which stands for Environmental, Social, and Governance factors, has gained prominence as a key consideration for university leaders and boards. Integrating ESG principles into the strategic plans of colleges and universities is critical for attracting and retaining students, faculty, and staff who share these values. Additionally, it fosters a more sustainable and responsible approach to operations and investments. Beyond environmental initiatives, many institutions are making significant progress in incorporating ESG principles into both their curriculum and daily operations.

Currently, CMU has implemented several forward-thinking initiatives in line with the growing emphasis on ESG principles. Notably, CMU has developed the Carnegie Mellon ESG-GED Index, designed to “measure U.S. companies’ environmental performance, focusing on Gross External Damage (GED) ... rather than standard ESG indices that measure emissions in tons” ([ESG](#)). This unique approach allows for a more comprehensive evaluation of environmental impact. Additionally, CMU offers the Sustainability Studio, an inclusive resource for the entire university community to explore and address issues related to equity, in support of social, economic, and environmental justice.

As extreme weather events and environmental challenges increase, ESG's significance will only grow, especially for organizations committed to making a positive social impact and fulfilling their broader responsibilities to society.

THREATS

- 1. Competition from Reputable Universities with a specialization in the Tech. Field**
- 2. Rising Costs of Student Tuition Due to Inflation**
- 3. Alternative Online Learning Platforms and Education**

THREAT 1 – Competition from Reputable Universities with a specialization in the Tech. Field

Carnegie Mellon University is a top research university in the country, and it is competing with several other top and prestigious universities. Carnegie Mellon is known for its top-notch computer science and artificial intelligence programs. Institutions like MIT and Caltech ([U.S. News, 2024](#)) have also had a strong reputation in computer science and artificial intelligence programs. This has brought up the competition between universities, which can impact CMU’s ability to attract top faculty and students. The faculty and students might choose to attend other universities due to the high competition. Furthermore, other universities might offer more financial aid and better amenities for students which will become a threat in the future for CMU to maintain its competitive edge.

THREAT 2 – Rising Costs of Student Tuition Due to Inflation

Carnegie Mellon was a private university, so the cost of attending the school was high. The steady rise of inflation shows a direct impact on the cost of students' tuition. The average tuition for CMU is around 65k with the national average cost of tuition of 45k ([U.S. News, 2024](#)). CMU is facing a growing challenge in maintaining its image, especially from students who come from middle-class or lower-class backgrounds. Some students might think the tuition is too expensive and is not worth attending school. The high cost of tuition and student debt may cause students to attend public universities because it would be more affordable. This could be a threat to CMU due to the fact of a diverse school. At the same time, other top-tier universities are

increasing their competition and offering more affordable tuition to students. This is why the rise of student tuition due to inflation at CMU is considered a threat in the future.

THREAT 3 – Alternative Online Learning Platforms and Education

The rapid growth of remote learning platforms and the increasing availability of remote learning have been a significant threat to top-tier universities worldwide. The online course was cheaper and offered a more flexible time for students to take and get their degrees. They are questioning the necessity of spending a large amount of money to attend a physical university.

There are also fewer international students due to the high cost and decide to study in their own country which also offers a decent education. This may cause CMU to reduce international student enrollment which will lose the tuition fees, the threat is impacting both the revenue and the diversity of the universities.

PART III – Analysis of Strategies

SO STRATEGIES

1. **(S1 / O1) - Utilizing CMU's research and resources that have driven its academic excellence to establish the university as a leader in AI and machine learning.**
2. **(S1 / O2) - Enhance and expand CMU's existing online learning platforms to meet growing demand and extend the university's global reach.**
3. **(S2 / O3) - Encourage and promote collaboration across departments to leverage diverse skill sets for developing effective and innovative ESG initiatives.**

SO STRATEGY 1 – (S1 / O1) - Utilizing CMU's research and resources that have driven its academic excellence to establish the university as a leader in AI and machine learning.

Expanding AI and ML Research Programs

CMU can utilize its existing AI research infrastructure to develop new programs that emphasize interdisciplinary collaboration, allowing students to work alongside industry professionals on innovative projects in the AI space. Such an expansion would enable CMU to remain at the forefront of AI advancements, providing students with unique opportunities to contribute to cutting-edge research. By increasing partnerships with leading tech companies, CMU can give students access to real-world problems, helping them develop solutions that could potentially lead to new technology ventures and innovations emerging from the university. A stronger focus on AI and ML will also increase CMU's visibility in the global academic community.

Increasing the Number of AI-Focused Courses

Offering more AI-centered courses across various disciplines would ensure that students from diverse academic backgrounds have the opportunity to gain in-demand skills in AI and ML.

Expanding coursework in this area not only enhances CMU's appeal but also prepares students to tackle industry challenges with a robust understanding of AI technologies.

Positioning CMU as an AI Innovation Hub

Investing in AI research and education can position CMU as a central hub for AI innovation. This would attract potential startup founders and entrepreneurs looking to develop AI-based solutions, potentially leading to new technology ventures and innovations emerging from CMU. A stronger emphasis on AI and ML will increase CMU's visibility in the global academic community, further solidifying its reputation as a leader in this field. ([Medium](#))

SO STRATEGY 2 – (S1 / O2) - Enhance and expand CMU's existing online learning platforms to meet growing demand and extend the university's global reach.

Catering to a Global Audience

An online platform would enable CMU to extend its expertise to students worldwide, especially international students and working professionals who seek more flexible education options. Online programs tailored to the diverse needs of this audience would not only expand CMU's reach but also strengthen its global reputation as an inclusive university. Providing access to students in underserved communities, as well as adults looking to upskill, could position CMU as a leader in remote education.

Generating New Revenue Streams

Expanding online offerings could provide CMU with additional revenue streams. Tapping into the online education market would allow CMU to allocate some of the revenue towards on-campus initiatives and reinvest profits into making programs and courses more robust and accessible for all students. This strategy aligns with the broader trend of shifting towards online and remote education.

Enhancing CMU's International Presence

As CMU expands into online educational offerings, it can strengthen its position as a leader in global education. Having a broader variety of online courses and programs will enable CMU to establish a larger online presence and build a reputation of excellence among international alumni, industry professionals, and potential students. This will further convey CMU's commitment to providing a world-class education, encouraging more individuals to become part of the university community. ([Agile](#))

SO STRATEGY 3 – (S2 / O3) - Encourage and promote collaboration across departments to leverage diverse skill sets for developing effective and innovative ESG initiatives.

Interdisciplinary Research on ESG Issues

CMU can build on its collaborative culture by encouraging departments in engineering, business, and humanities to work together on projects focused on sustainability. These interdisciplinary projects could address real-world ESG challenges that companies face, preparing students for an ever-changing environment that requires adaptable solutions.

Creating Partnerships with Industry and Government

A focus on ESG could attract partnerships with companies and government organizations seeking to collaborate on sustainability solutions. These partnerships would provide valuable resources for research and allow students to work on projects with a real societal impact. Such collaborations could lead to innovative breakthroughs and establish CMU as a thought leader in the sustainability space.

Positioning CMU as a Leader in Sustainability

Incorporating ESG into the curriculum and research agenda would allow CMU to appeal to students who are passionate about climate change and other global issues. This approach could also help CMU differentiate itself from competitors, attracting students, faculty, and partners who share a commitment to making a positive impact. Additionally, it could draw in valuable company partnerships focused on innovative ESG technology. ([Medium](#))

WO STRATEGIES

1. **(W1 / O2) - Offer affordable online certification programs to provide low-income students with more accessible options.**
2. **(W2 / O3) - Differentiate the school by establishing it as a leader in sustainability and green initiatives.**
3. **(W3 / O3) - Develop sustainability initiatives to enhance student engagement and enrich campus life.**

WO STRATEGY 1 – (W1 / O2) - Offer affordable online certification programs to provide low-income students with more accessible options.

CMU faces the challenge of high tuition costs, which can limit access for many prospective students, particularly those from lower-income backgrounds ([Career Karma](#)). By providing affordable online certification programs, CMU can offer lower-cost alternatives that make its education more accessible without compromising the quality of instruction. However, the growing demand for online education presents a significant opportunity for CMU to address this issue by expanding its offerings in online and remote learning. CMU should consider broadening its online education portfolio by developing modular, lower-cost certification programs, as well as continuing to expand its selection of online degree programs, such as Part-time MSBA. By breaking down existing programs into smaller, more affordable certifications, CMU can make its prestigious education more accessible to a wider audience. Offering low-cost certifications promotes educational equity by allowing low-income students to gain in-demand skills without

taking on massive student debt. It also aligns with the broader trend of social responsibility and ESG, which universities are increasingly adopting. CMU could position itself as a university committed to diversity and inclusion, which can improve its overall reputation and attract a more diverse student body.

Modular and Stackable Certifications

CMU could develop modular, stackable certification programs where students can complete individual certifications at a low cost and eventually stack them to build toward a more comprehensive degree or qualification. This would allow students to pay as they go, offering financial flexibility and reducing the burden of large upfront costs.

Partner with Industry

CMU can form partnerships with tech companies and industry leaders to co-develop these online certification programs. Industry partnerships would provide legitimacy, ensure that the curriculum aligns with job market demands, and offer pathways to internships or job placements. This could also lead to potential scholarships or corporate-sponsored programs to further reduce the cost for low-income students.

Robust Online Learning Platform

To ensure success, CMU must invest in a robust online learning platform that offers interactive and engaging course delivery, with high-quality digital resources, faculty engagement, and peer-to-peer interaction. Effective online learning experiences are critical to maintaining CMU's reputation for academic rigor, even in lower-cost formats.

Scalability and Global Reach

Online education allows CMU to reach students globally without the limitations of physical infrastructure. This helps CMU tap into new markets and increase enrollment without significantly raising operational costs. Expanding into online education provides flexibility for students from different time zones and backgrounds, enhancing CMU's global presence.

Selective Admission for Brand Prestige

Additionally, CMU could implement selective admissions standards for its online degree programs to maintain the university's reputation for academic excellence, while offering these programs at a reduced cost.

By offering a range of online certifications and degrees, CMU could diversify its revenue streams. This would help buffer against fluctuations in traditional tuition revenue while positioning the university as a leader in flexible, innovative learning solutions. This approach not only addresses the cost barrier for many students but also taps into the expanding online education market, aligning CMU with current educational trends and needs.

WO STRATEGY 2 – (W2 / O3) - Differentiate the school by establishing it as a leader in sustainability and green initiatives.

With its brand value trailing behind top tech-focused universities like MIT, CMU can capitalize on the growing global focus on ESG and climate change to differentiate itself. By strategically incorporating ESG principles into its vision and curriculum, CMU can position itself as a tech-driven university committed to environmental responsibility. Leveraging its expertise in technology and engineering, CMU can focus on innovative climate solutions and sustainable technologies like renewable energy and smart cities. Expanding ESG-related research centers, such as the Scott Institute for Energy Innovation, will boost CMU's visibility as a leader in addressing critical environmental and social challenges. Furthermore, CMU can enhance its global brand by collaborating with industries, governments, and NGOs on high-impact ESG projects, while actively promoting its research achievements through media campaigns, academic publications, and participation in global ESG conferences.

Enhances Campus Engagement and Student Life

Establishing sustainability initiatives not only improves the university's public image but also enhances campus life by fostering collaboration, innovation, and activism around shared goals. This could involve student-led sustainability projects, sustainable campus operations, and interdisciplinary research on climate tech.

Strengthens CMU's Reputation for Tech and Innovation

CMU already has strengths in technology and innovation, and a sustainability focus allows the university to apply these strengths to address climate and environmental challenges. Initiatives such as smart cities, green energy tech, or sustainable engineering solutions could position CMU as a global leader in the intersection of tech and ESG ([Dyer](#)).

Integrate Sustainability Across Departments

CMU should embed sustainability principles into its curriculum across departments, not just in environmental studies, but also in fields like engineering, AI, and data analytics. This creates a culture of sustainability while leveraging the university's technological expertise.

Host High-Profile ESG Events

CMU can host global events like climate action conferences or ESG tech summits, which would bring together global thought leaders, businesses, and policymakers. These events would position the university as a thought leader in ESG, improving its global recognition.

WO STRATEGY 3 – (W3 / O3) - Develop sustainability initiatives to enhance student engagement and enrich campus life.

To address the weakness of limited campus life, CMU can enhance its sustainability efforts, transforming the campus into a model for sustainable living and operations. One strategy would be to host high-profile conferences and forums on topics like climate change, ethical technology, and sustainable governance, drawing global thought leaders, industry innovators, and policymakers to campus ([Van](#)). These events would not only boost CMU's visibility but also create a dynamic and engaging environment for students.

Fostering a Sense of Community

Sustainability initiatives typically involve collaboration, whether through student-led clubs, partnerships with local businesses, or cross-departmental projects. These activities foster a sense of belonging, which enhances student engagement and enriches the campus culture, ultimately improving student satisfaction and retention.

Sustainability Festivals and Workshops

Additionally, CMU could hold annual sustainability festivals that bring the student body together. These festivals could feature workshops on sustainability, eco-product expos, and guest speakers from global climate organizations. Collaborative climate-awareness projects would encourage participation and foster a sense of community around ESG values.

Cross-discipline ESG events

To further engage students, CMU could organize ESG-themed hackathons and innovation challenges focused on reducing carbon footprints or addressing global environmental issues. These interdisciplinary activities would encourage student collaboration, enhance campus vibrancy, and position CMU as a hub for sustainability-driven innovation.

This multifaceted approach would strengthen campus life while aligning with the global focus on environmental and social responsibility.

ST STRATEGIES

1. **(S3 / T3) - Promote CMU's diverse and inclusive campus experience to highlight the opportunity cost for students who opt for online or remote learning platforms and miss out on campus life.**
2. **(S1 / T2) - Justify CMU's high tuition costs by highlighting its academic excellence and strong post-graduation outcomes, offering a high return on investment.**
3. **(S2 / T1) - Leveraging interdisciplinary strengths (e.g. technology, arts, humanities, etc.) to promote cross-departmental collaboration and differentiate from competing schools that solely specialize in technology.**

ST STRATEGY 1 – (S3 / T3) - Promote CMU's diverse and inclusive campus experience to highlight the opportunity cost for students who opt for online or remote learning platforms and miss out on campus life.

Encourage Collaboration and Networking skills

CMU has a diversity compass that offers a rich learning experience and environment for both personal and collaboration growth. It gives students a better chance to iterate with each other from different backgrounds. This is an aspect that the diverse campus will never be accomplished by a remote learning environment. Students can learn more, engage better with face-to-face interactions, and have a more dynamic academic community. It is important to have students engage together from different diverse backgrounds. The real-world exposure is harder to

replicate in an online environment. CMU offers a diverse campus that will foster deeper connections and understanding which is highly valued in the work field nowadays. ([The Princeton Review](#)). The significant point that attracts students to attend in-person universities is not only seeking education but an experience and connections that will last for their lives.

Mentorship and Career Development

The diverse campus of Carnegie Mellon University has also offered mentorship opportunities from the faculty of the school. This way it creates a bond between the students and the mentor who can give a lot of advice to them in the work field. By meeting the mentors in person, it can build a special relationship with the students. It was more challenging to build a relationship only based on online interactions. Mentors can connect students to industry professionals and alumni which can help students to get more opportunities. CMU also offers career fairs which also gives more connections between the students and the companies. By directly in-person networking, students have a better chance of securing a position in a job and advancing in their future careers.

Immersive Campus Experience

Carnegie Mellon University has an immersive campus and learning experience for students who are attending here. Students can go beyond their academic work and engage in student organizations and clubs. These opportunities can contribute a lot to the personal growth of students which remote learning cannot provide. Based on every student's interest, they can join the club they like and meet people who are also interested in the same subject. Daily campus life is going to be more engaging and interesting. These experiences will contribute to personal development and leadership skills. Engaging with a diverse group of people can help students develop a global perspective and how to succeed in the modern world.

Why This Strategy Will Succeed:

Experiential Learning: By improving CMU's programs, offering hands-on experience in technology and arts. This is an important part of developing practical skills and creativity. Which cannot be done in an online environment.

Increase Access to Personal Support: Remote learning lacks personal support and resources. CMU could use more in-person support to make students feel more comfortable and connected within the community.

Enhance Marketing and Communication: CMU could highlight the distinctive benefits of its campus being diverse and inclusive. This will let the community know that attending CMU is better than attending an online university.

ST STRATEGY 2 – (S1 / T2) - Justify CMU's high tuition costs by highlighting its academic excellence and strong post-graduation outcomes, offering a high return on investment.

World-Class Programs

By offering a variety of world-class programs, Carnegie Mellon University has ranked among the top universities globally. Particularly in the field of computer science and artificial intelligence. Its school of computer science is ranked number two in the US and robotics and

engineering are also considered one of the top in the world. ([AdmissionSight](#)). The reputation of the school was a strategy that students would think that the high tuition was worth. It will ensure that every student here gets an equal opportunity to receive one of the best education and make them competitive and skilled in the job market.

Post-Graduation Outcomes

On average, CMU graduates in the field of computer science and artificial intelligence have excellent job opportunities and high starting salaries. The earnings after you graduate can cover the cost of education and most of the students will be getting a job after graduation. CMU also has strong industry connections. For example, big companies like Google and Amazon have offered CMU students the opportunity of internships and later recruitment. Even though the student's tuition is high at CMU, the opportunity of holding a CMU degree will outweigh the high cost of attending the university. The School of Computer Science and Tepper School of Business has reported some of the highest average salaries in the current industry. This made CMU education worth the high tuition cost.

Cross-Disciplinary Learning Opportunities

By allowing CMU students to engage in programs in different fields, such as Arts and design that require technology. It will integrate technical disciplines that will let the students learn more skills from different subjects. By paying a high tuition fee, students should be able to attend more classes and learn more besides their major requirements. This approach will let their career have more options in both technical and creative fields. This will make the tuition fee more worth paying. For example, programs like the Entertainment Technology Center will provide students with a more comprehensive education bridging their technical skills to other skills that they might need in their future careers.

Why This Strategy Will Succeed:

Superior Post-Graduation Outcomes: CMU will prepare students for a high-demand career in technology and other industries. The high tuition cost will be covered by the salaries of the job. Students will invest the money in the degree and get a high-paying job in their career advancement.

Collaboration and Networking: By paying a high tuition cost, students will benefit from my collaboration among a diverse group of students. It also provides a networking opportunity that allows students to engage with each other with different professional backgrounds.

Support and Campus Resources: CMU is offering personalized support for every student. The career counseling and mental health resources are all included in the tuition fee. This will also contribute to academic success and individual development which was difficult to achieve not attending the university.

ST STRATEGY 3 – (S2 / T1) - Leveraging interdisciplinary strengths (e.g. technology, arts, humanities, etc.) to promote cross-departmental collaboration and differentiate from competing schools that solely specialize in technology.

Integration of Art and Technology

CMU is different from its competitors because of its interaction approach to arts and technology. Certain programs will bridge the gap between arts and tech which offers students to engage in more projects that combine different skills. Universities like MIT and Caltech are heavily focused on technology and are not offering those kinds of projects. CMU is getting students to have a unique edge in which they are not only skilled in technology but also in creativity. This strategy will allow CMU to be better compared to its competitors. The creativity of students and alumni can be in gaming and interactive media in the future instead of only focusing on software engineering. ([Stanton University](#)).

Focusing on Creativity

Schools like MIT tend to focus heavily on technological parts. This will show a clear contrast if we improve and emphasize the creativity and innovation side of CMU. This will make the school more versatile for students who are interested in learning more skills. CMU already has a well-established art department. The program was excellent in music and visual arts which produced a lot of notable alumni in the industry. The combination of tech and creativity is what makes CMU stand out in its competition. It will also attract more students to go to CMU and want to work in the intersection of technology and creativity. For example, a student interested in game design would be an excellent choice to attend CMU. They will be equipped with excellent technological skills and art skills which are fit for the role.

Strong Technical Program

Despite the excellent art programs that are offered at CMU, the School of Computer Science is ranked among the top in the world. Especially in the area of machine learning and artificial intelligence. The university has a lot of resources in the tech field and innovation research center. The technological programs are comparable to MIT's which both provide students with the best education and opportunities. CMU will provide students with better industry connections which will be a better result in the work field. While MIT and CMU both are excellent in the pure technology field, CMU offers a wider variety of good majors that will enhance students' problem-solving skills in a real work environment.

Why This Strategy Will Succeed:

Unique Education Opportunity: CMU can offer a more well-rounded education for the students. Programs that combine fields such as technology and arts are one of a kind. This blend of distinctive education will let the students stand out in the job market.

Better Skill Sets: Offering a better and broader skill set to students at CMU, will bring different perspectives to the people. The multi-dimensional approach can give students a better advantage compared to students at MIT.

Enhanced Collaborations: CMU encourages cross-departmental collaboration. This fosters creativity and other skills of students. This can be enhanced in different industries like Artificial intelligence and design.

WT STRATEGIES

1. **(W1 / T2) - Investigate new strategies to enhance funding for student scholarships and financial aid.**
2. **(W2 / T1) - Establish new global partnerships and strengthen existing ones to enhance international presence and reach.**
3. **(W3 / T3) - Focus on increasing funding and efforts to host more social networking events on campus.**

WT STRATEGY 1 – (W1 / T2) - Investigate new strategies to enhance funding for student scholarships and financial aid.

To address the weakness of high tuition costs and the threat of rising tuition fees, Carnegie Mellon University (CMU) should focus on increasing financial aid and scholarships through innovative strategies.

Establish New Global Scholarship Programs

CMU could create new global scholarship programs specifically targeting underrepresented international students who demonstrate financial need. By establishing partnerships with international organizations and governments, CMU can provide scholarships that cover tuition and living expenses for talented students from developing countries. This initiative would not only enhance CMU's global footprint but also diversify its student body, making it more attractive to prospective students.

For example, CMU could collaborate with organizations like the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) to promote educational accessibility and provide funding for students from specific regions. Establishing a presence in international educational fairs and recruiting efforts can also help attract students who would benefit from such scholarships.

Introduce a Sliding-scale Tuition Model

CMU could consider implementing a sliding scale tuition model based on family income, where tuition costs are adjusted according to the financial situation of each student. This model would ensure that students from lower-income backgrounds pay less, while those from higher-income families contribute a proportionate amount. This approach can make education more accessible and may be more sustainable than traditional financial aid models. Research indicates that such models can lead to increased enrollment and retention rates, as they remove financial barriers for low-income students ([rsfjournal](#)). However, the university would need to assess the long-term financial implications of utilizing this system and ensure it is sustainable.

Launch a Crowdfunding Platform for Student Aid

While CMU has TartanFunder, a new, dedicated crowdfunding initiative focused solely on raising funds for student scholarships could be promoted. This campaign could encourage alumni, students, and community members to contribute to a central fund that directly impacts financial aid packages. This platform could allow students, alumni, and community members to contribute directly to scholarship funds for those in need. CMU could encourage participation by

highlighting specific stories of students who would benefit from these funds, further fostering a sense of community and personal connection to the contributions.

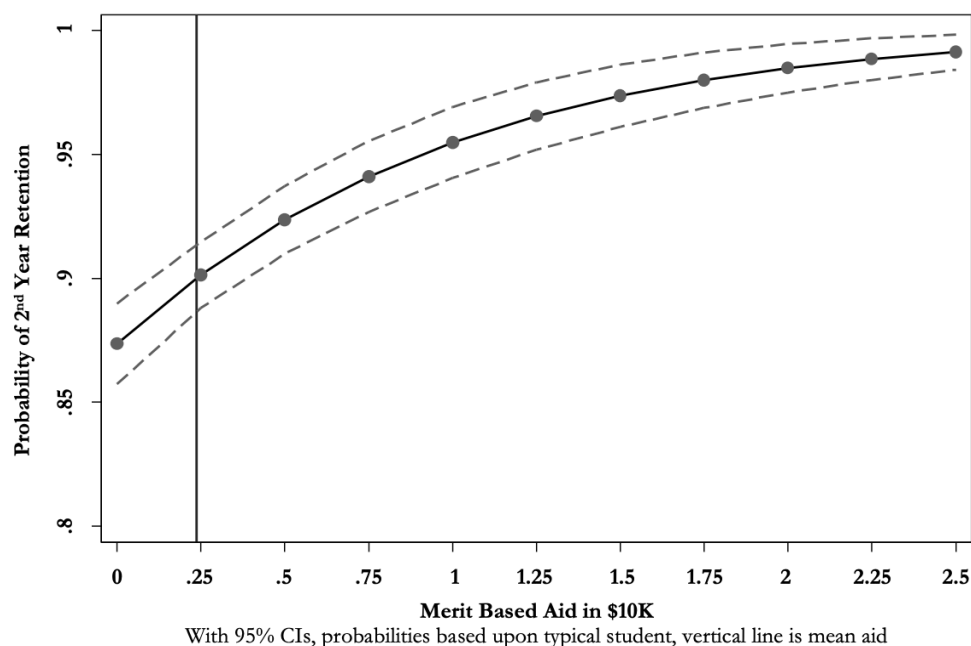
Such platforms have been successfully utilized by various universities to promote specific initiatives and could provide CMU with a more dynamic way to engage potential donors. By highlighting the tangible impact of contributions on students' lives, CMU can increase funding for scholarships and financial aid.

Why This Strategy Will Succeed:

Enhanced Access to Financial Aid: By creating global scholarship programs and a sliding-scale tuition model, CMU can make education more affordable and accessible to a wider range of students, particularly those from low- and middle-income families.

Increased Enrollment and Retention: Research has shown that sliding-scale tuition models and enhanced financial aid lead to higher enrollment and retention rates (refer to the figure below). Making tuition more affordable for a diverse range of students will likely improve CMU's ability to attract and retain a strong, talented student body, contributing to the institution's long-term financial health.

Figure 2. Institutional Aid and Retention



[\(Journal of Student Financial Aid\)](#)

Community and Alumni Engagement: This initiative can increase financial contributions, enhance community support, and foster a deeper connection between donors and the university. This highlights how the direct impact of donations on student lives can drive ongoing engagement and sustainable financial aid growth.

WT STRATEGY 2 – (W2 / T1) - Establish new global partnerships and strengthen existing ones to enhance international presence and reach.

To effectively combat CMU's weakness of comparatively low brand/name value and the threat posed by competition from prestigious tech institutions, CMU should implement a focused strategy on strengthening and expanding global partnerships. By enhancing its international presence, CMU can both elevate its brand and differentiate itself in a highly competitive market.

Global Partnerships and Collaborations

To address the weakness of lower brand recognition compared to institutions like MIT and Stanford, CMU should form more partnerships with international universities, research institutions, and tech companies in key global regions such as Asia, Europe, and the Middle East.

By collaborating on cutting-edge technologies like artificial intelligence, data science, and robotics, CMU could position itself as a global leader in innovation. Partnering on large-scale research initiatives similar to MIT's Singapore-MIT Alliance for Research and Technology (SMART) or NYU's global campuses could elevate CMU's brand and research output, attracting greater attention worldwide ([Nature](#)). These collaborations could lead to joint research centers or dual-degree programs, making CMU a desirable partner for academic and industry leaders. Furthermore, CMU should continuously aim to strengthen its existing global partnerships to foster more collaboration, innovation, and growth.

Expansion of Global Campuses and Innovation Hubs

Building on the success of CMU Qatar, CMU could explore the establishment of new campuses or innovation hubs in emerging tech regions such as Southeast Asia, India, and South America. These regions are experiencing rapid technological growth, and a CMU presence there could help meet rising educational demands while fostering local research and innovation in these rapidly evolving markets.

Expanding internationally not only differentiates CMU from other tech universities but also increases its reach, positioning it as a key player in global tech education. This would enhance the university's global standing while providing access to new pools of talent.

Leveraging International Research and Alumni Networks

CMU could leverage its existing global research network and alumni connections to elevate its profile further. CMU's international alumni are already influential in various industries, and mobilizing them for mentorship programs, global conferences, and international outreach could enhance the university's reputation globally.

CMU can also focus on establishing collaborative research projects with global institutions on emerging topics such as AI, robotics, sustainability, and clean energy, which can significantly raise CMU's academic profile and align it with institutions that lead in these areas.

Why This Strategy Will Succeed:

Increased Brand Recognition: By building partnerships and expanding globally, CMU would become more visible on the world stage, which would address its lower brand value compared to competitors.

Differentiation from Competitors: Establishing new and enhancing existing international campuses and research hubs would set CMU apart from other tech institutions, allowing it to attract a higher pool of diverse talents and research opportunities.

Stronger Industry and Academic Ties: Through global collaborations and research, CMU can strengthen its relationships with top companies and institutions, which will help ensure its long-term competitiveness in the global tech educational market.

WT STRATEGY 3 – (W3 / T3) - Focus on increasing funding and efforts to host more social networking events on campus.

To address the weakness of limited campus life and the threat posed by alternative online learning platforms, Carnegie Mellon University (CMU) should focus on strengthening student engagement through social events and fostering a stronger sense of community on campus.

Although CMU may already have implemented similar initiatives, the strategy revolves more around enhancing CMU's focus, effort, and funding for more socialization opportunities.

Enhancing Campus Life with the Development of More Student-Centric Social Events

To improve the student experience, CMU should allocate increased funding and resources to create more opportunities for social interaction and community building. This could involve the establishment of a dedicated student life team consisting of faculty members who work closely with a student advisory board to organize frequent social events, networking opportunities, and cross-disciplinary activities. For example, hosting more regular events such as cultural festivals, expos, or community outreach programs would allow students to form connections, develop leadership skills, and deepen their engagement with campus life.

Although CMU already hosts a wide range of social events, along with various student organizations, leadership programs, and professional networking events, aimed at enriching campus life, CMU is still commonly depicted as a school that lacks a vibrant social scene for its students. Instead, CMU is well-known to be a school that has a stressful and intense learning environment. Therefore, CMU could still benefit from expanding social events specifically targeting students' networking and collaboration opportunities. For example, assigning dedicated faculty-student teams to organize more frequent, theme-based networking events could enhance the university's appeal and sense of community. Furthermore, CMU can look to host more events that are open to all students so that they can provide opportunities to students from different departments and disciplines to socialize and network. Lastly, another potential strategy would be to host more fundraising events that could allow students to not only socialize with one another

but also allow them to collaborate and connect to achieve a common goal of raising funds for a specific cause.

The creation of more unique and appealing campus-wide social events not only strengthens the sense of belonging but also addresses the competition from other online learning platforms, which often lack the social component of actually attending the physical university.

Creating More Dedicated Social Spaces

CMU should consider investing in more physical spaces dedicated to fostering social life and community engagement. For instance:

- Dedicated networking lounges or innovation labs where students from different disciplines can gather to exchange ideas.
- Student-driven initiatives: Encouraging student organizations to focus on hosting more events, creating more clubs, or running more activities to bridge the academic and social life gap.
- Virtual campus tours and community-building apps can integrate CMU's online learners into the broader university network, helping mitigate the threat of alternative online education by offering students a robust sense of connection to CMU.

Leveraging Partnerships for Community Enrichment

To further enrich campus life, CMU can collaborate with more local businesses, tech companies, and global partners to co-host events that combine professional development with social engagement. By partnering with more tech giants, CMU can host more hackathons, tech talks, or innovation competitions, offering students access to industry leaders, while also making the campus life experience more engaging. These programs would integrate professional and social networking opportunities that keep students invested in their on-campus experience, something online learning platforms often fail to deliver.

Why This Strategy Will Succeed:

- **Enhanced Student Engagement:** By improving social interactions, students are more likely to feel a sense of belonging, improving retention and satisfaction. A strong sense of community can often be a significant benefit, especially when competing with purely academic, online alternatives.
- **Differentiation from Online Platforms:** CMU's hybrid approach, combining both global networking from partnerships and vibrant campus life, would make its educational experience more appealing than the limited engagement offered by online education platforms.
- **Strengthened Global Presence:** By utilizing its global campuses and partnerships, CMU can offer both local and international students unparalleled networking opportunities, ensuring its graduates are well-connected globally.